

Memory Overload!

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I remember June 2001 very distinctly!

Digit had a predecessor (that shall not be named), which started in 1998, a partnership between a German and an Indian publisher. In 2001, that partnership crumbled and Digit was launched. My local newspaper stall handed Digit to me, insisting it was much better than its predecessor – “A likely story,” I thought, given that he wanted to continue my monthly business. He wasn’t lying; Digit was the technology revolution that India needed.

Unlike its predecessor, which felt like it was trying too hard to be international, Digit was unabashedly Indian. With stories about email in vernacular languages, discussions about custom fees on imported tech, headlines in Hinglish... it felt at home on an Indian newsstand – even if the price was still international! Back then ₹100 was a very steep price, given that my shared room in Bandra, Mumbai, cost ₹1,000 a month! I had to actually skip a few meals every week to save up for my Digit fix!

If I’m being honest, I only read the magazine in the second week of June 2001, because the CDs were like manna from heaven in a bandwidth-starved nation! If any OG subscribers are reading this, they’re violently nodding their heads in agreement, and shuddering at the memory of the nightmarishly slow pre-broadband era internet download speeds of 2001!

What I absolutely loved about that first issue of Digit was the letters section. Instead of brushing it under the carpet, here was a magazine sharing hate mail from its own subscribers! It was ballsy, and it was the attitude that would be stuck with Digit forever.

I’d find out later that while common sense would have suggested that, at least for the first issue, Digit put out a reduced print run. If the hate mail from subscribers were anything to go by, any MBA-qualified decision maker worth their salt would have halved the print run! Not the geeks at Digit; they *increased* the print run from 100,000 to 120,000! And thus was born the belief that Digit, ‘Your technology navigator’, would always do the impossible!

I could share a hundred more stories like this! Stories about meeting so many of you across the country,

thrashing you in *Quake III Arena* and Unreal Tournament at SKOAR! Expos, blowing up a one-of-a-kind R&D motherboard from Intel in a failed liquid nitrogen overclock session, countless all-nighters spent on insane projects and PC builds, stealing IT passwords to install the Digit Forum without permission, playing practical jokes on readers and (whitehat) phishing 20,000 Gmail passwords, crashing BlackBerry’s servers by stress-testing BBM group chats with 10,000 readers... and more!

When I joined Digit in Jan 2003, right until I moved on in March 2023, doing the impossible was demanded of me, and was what I demanded of my colleagues. There’s a good reason why people who used to work at Digit are thriving at the biggest tech companies in India and abroad – you had to be special to withstand the constant demand for excellence!

Digit has had a massive impact on India using the universal language of technology; but you know that already. You wouldn’t be reading this unless you also valued the special bond you have with this brilliant brand, and appreciated what it’s done over the past 25 years!

I feel privileged to have been a part of Digit’s history, and now that I’m back to being a reader, I’m excited to see the new heights Digit will scale in the next 25 years! 

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